

where notifications are visible on top of the screen, the live tiles of Windows Phone 8 not only show the notification on top but also keep it live on the home-screen, i.e., live tiles.

Better hardware capability. Unlike Windows Phone 7.5 (for phones with 256MB RAM), Windows Phone 8 was meant to offer the Windows experience at a premium level. This has been made possible by equipping the OS to be compatible with high-end hardware (1.5GHz processor and 1GB RAM).

Bluetooth and expandable storage. Many Windows Phone 7.5 users have complained about the absence of Bluetooth connectivity, which sounded really bizarre (although that was sorted with Windows Phone 7.8). With Windows Phone 8 not only do users get Bluetooth but they are also capable of expanding their memory storage.

Not so much hardware driven. While Android versions (4.0 and above) have a specific hardware requirement, Windows Phone 8 is not a hardware-hungry platform and is capable of running on different hardware without too much of hassle.

Who should buy Windows Phone 8 smartphones

The phones that run Windows Phone 8 offer an experience that varies from the Android and iOS platforms. Microsoft has tried doing basic things in a simple manner. A first-time smartphone buyer who does not really look much into the Android-vs-Windows Phone 8 debate could definitely go for a Windows Phone 8 device.

Windows Phone 8 phones available in the market right now do not offer the luxury of quad cores and big displays like 12.7 cm (5 inches), but for an average customer an 11.4cm (4.5-inch) display (such as in Nokia Lumia 920) will be reasonably good.

Due to hardware limitations, these phones do not offer the best gaming experience (but the display is worth appreciating). Also, with 512MB RAM, most of the popular games available on the platform, such as Temple Run, are incompatible with the phone. The app ecosystem needs to be strengthened quickly. If you are ready to wait for the platform to mature and evolve in the coming months, Windows Phone 8 is best suited for you.

OPTIONS TO CHOOSE FROM

Currently, options in Windows Phone 8 devices are limited to only two brands in India: Nokia and HTC. But over the last couple of months, we have seen the Windows Phone 8 portfolio of Nokia expanding from two devices (Lumia 920 and Lumia 820) to five devices (Lumia 620, Lumia 520 and Lumia 720).

Nokia Lumia 520

It is the cheapest and the latest Windows Phone 8 smartphone offering in India as well as globally. Priced at Rs 10,499, this phone comes with basic Windows Phone 8 hardware and offers the premium Windows Phone 8 interface experience. It sports a 10.1cm (4-inch) display and is powered by a 1GHz dual-core processor with 512MB RAM. It has a 5MP rear camera without LED flash.



| Price: ₹ 10,499

Nokia Lumia 620

This offering from Nokia is the perfect combination of affordability and premium Windows Phone 8 interface. As mentioned above, the hardware of Lumia 520 and 620 are almost similar, but Lumia 620 comes with a 9.1cm (3.8-inch) display, VGA front-facing camera, LED flash for the rear camera and NFC support. Lumia 620, with all these features, is priced at ₹ 14,500.



| Price: ₹ 14,500

HTC 8S

HTC had launched its Windows Phone 8 offering in India last year and since then there have been no additions to its line-up. Its 8S comes with a 10.1cm display, and is powered by a 1GHz processor with 512MB RAM. However, the phone sports 5MP rear camera only. One of the biggest drawbacks is the lack of apps (which are available on Nokia phones) for camera, navigation, music, etc. With a 1700mAh battery, the phone is priced at ₹ 18,500.

| Price: ₹ 18,500

